The Source of Our Disturbances: Epictetus on Views, Not Things

Introduction

Epictetus (c. 55 – 135 AD), a profoundly influential Greek Stoic philosopher, articulated a fundamental principle that continues to resonate through centuries of thought: human emotional disturbance originates not from external events themselves, but rather from the judgments and interpretations individuals form about those events. Born into slavery and later achieving freedom, Epictetus's teachings, meticulously recorded by his devoted student Arrian in the *Discourses* and the *Enchiridion* (Handbook), offer a practical and enduring guide to achieving inner peace and flourishing (*eudaimonia*).[1] His philosophy, deeply rooted in the foundational tenets of early Stoicism, placed a strong emphasis on ethics and practical moral training as the path to a well-lived life.[1]

This report will meticulously delineate how Epictetus explained this core principle. It will explore the philosophical mechanisms he identified—such as the dichotomy of control, the nature of impressions and assent, and the unique human faculty of *prohairesis*—and detail the practical disciplines he prescribed for cultivating a resilient and rational emotional state.

1. The Cornerstone: Epictetus's Dichotomy of Control

Epictetus's assertion that an individual's emotional state is a direct consequence of their own opinions and interpretations is fundamentally rooted in his concept of the "dichotomy of control." This principle serves as the bedrock of his ethical system, guiding individuals to discern what truly lies within their sphere of influence and what does not.

Epictetus famously articulated this distinction, stating at the very outset of his *Enchiridion* that "Some things are in our control and others not".[3] This foundational principle is paramount for understanding the entirety of Stoic philosophy. Things identified as "up to us" (*eph' hēmin*) or within our control include our opinions (*doxa*), pursuits, desires, aversions, and, in essence, "whatever are our own actions".[3] These internal elements are inherently "free, unrestrained, unhindered".[9] Conversely, things "not up to us" (*ouk eph' hēmin*) or not within our control encompass external factors such as our body, property, reputation, command, and "whatever are not our own actions".[3] These external elements are described as "weak, slavish, restrained, belonging to others".[9]

Epictetus stressed that authentic freedom, profound happiness, and a state of serenity are attained by confining one's choices and focus exclusively to what is internal and within one's control.[6] When individuals direct their energy and aspirations toward their internal world—their thoughts, judgments, and responses—they engage with what is truly their own and inherently controllable. This alignment with one's internal agency leads to a sense of security and imperturbability, as these inner elements cannot be taken away or hindered by external forces.[11]

Conversely, desiring or pursuing things outside of one's control inevitably leads to hindrance, dissatisfaction, frustration, and unhappiness.[8] This arises because if an individual believes they

should control things that are inherently uncontrollable (e.g., the opinions of others, their wealth, or external events), then any deviation from their desired outcome for these external factors will necessarily result in distress. The perceived lack of control over externals, when coupled with the strong desire for such control, creates a fundamental clash between an individual's internal expectation and external reality. The emotional turmoil, therefore, does not stem from the external event itself, but from the internal resistance to its uncontrollable nature.

External things are inherently neutral, being "neither good nor bad".[7] Consequently, they should not be feared. From a Stoic perspective, even death, a natural occurrence, is not inherently bad; its negative perception arises solely from our judgment that we should live forever.[7] The objective is to align one's desires and aversions with what actually happens in the world, thereby eliminating the root cause of anxiety.[7] This profound acceptance of reality, often termed

Amor Fati (the loving acceptance of one's fate), is a central tenet of Stoic practice.[7]

This framework establishes that true freedom is an internal, psychological state, entirely independent of one's physical or social condition. Epictetus, himself a former slave, profoundly emphasized that "only our mental life (thoughts, beliefs, decisions, emotions) is in our power and so 'free'".[4] He further stated that the things within an individual's control are "by nature free, unrestrained, unhindered".[9] This perspective implies that a slave, by Epictetus's definition, can achieve a greater degree of freedom than an emperor if the slave masters their internal world while the emperor remains enslaved by desires for external power or reputation. This redefines "freedom" from a political or social status to a state of mind achieved through rigorous self-mastery.

By clearly delineating what is and is not within an individual's control at the outset, Epictetus provides a preventative measure against emotional disturbance. This is not merely a retrospective analysis of why one *is* disturbed, but a proactive framework designed to avoid disturbance in the first place. When this distinction is internalized, individuals can pre-emptively dismiss concerns about externals, thereby preventing the formation of distressing judgments. This makes the dichotomy of control not just a descriptive tool for understanding human experience, but a prescriptive one for mental well-being.

Table 1: Epictetus's Dichotomy of Control: What is "Up to Us" vs. "Not Up to Us"

Category	Within Our Control (*Eph' Hēmin*)	Not Within Our Control (*Ouk Eph' Hēmin*)
Internal	Opinions, Judgments, Thoughts, Beliefs, Desires, Aversions, Intentions, Choices, Actions, Moral Purpose (*Prohairesis*), Reactions to events, Attitudes towards events, Our own behavior, Use of impressions	(N/A)
External	(N/A)	Body (health, lameness, sickness), Property (wealth, possessions, lamp being stolen), Reputation (what others say, praise, criticism, social status), Command/Public Office, External Events (traffic jams, rain, death, job loss,

		relationship breakdowns), Other people's opinions, Societal expectations, Physical appearance, Outcomes of actions

2. The Mechanism of Perception and Judgment: Impressions (*Phantasia*) and Assent (*Synkatathesis*)

Epictetus's explanation of how views disturb individuals delves deeper into the cognitive process, focusing on the interplay between initial perceptions (impressions), the faculty of choice, and the crucial act of giving or withholding agreement (assent).

Phantasia refers to 'appearance' or 'impression'—the raw information derived from sense experience, perception, or mental representation.[1] For Stoics,

phantasiai are often pre-cognitive evaluations, influenced by prior experiences or subconscious thought patterns.[14] They represent the initial way things "strike you as being a certain way".[15] As human beings are rational, their impressions are termed "rational impressions," implying their content can be expressed in language.[15]

Synkatathesis, or assent, is the subsequent and critical cognitive act of taking an impression to be true. This act is entirely within an individual's volitional control, meaning one "may give or withhold at will".[1] It is the act of "rationally accepting or rejecting an impression".[16] If an individual assents to an unreliable impression, the result is mere fallible "opinion" (

doxa), not true cognition.[14] The Stoics maintained that while impressions themselves are often involuntary, the act of assenting to them is entirely within one's control.[17] Withholding this assent is therefore crucial for preventing emotional disturbance.[17]

Central to this process is *prohairesis*, a fundamental concept in Epictetus's philosophy, variously translated as "moral character," "will," "volition," "choice," or "moral choice".[18] Epictetus considered

prohairesis the faculty that distinguishes human beings from all other creatures.[18] For him,

prohairesis is the *only* thing fully within an individual's power to control.[18] It is the

faculty that exercises the choice used to judge impressions.[18] This rational faculty subordinates all other human faculties, is capable of using and understanding impressions, and can evaluate other faculties.[18] Crucially,

prohairesis is "impossible to be enslaved" or subordinated, even under the most extreme external pressures.[18] The concept of

prohairesis allowed Epictetus to place significant emphasis on individual moral identity and total responsibility for one's choices, reinforcing the idea of an inviolable inner autonomy.[4]

Emotional disturbance arises precisely from misjudging impressions and assenting to false propositions about external events. Epictetus explicitly states: "It is not the things themselves that disturb people but their judgements about those things".[7] Emotional turmoil emerges when individuals assign labels of "good" or "bad" to external circumstances, which are inherently neutral.[7] For instance, a traffic jam is merely a traffic jam; it becomes frustrating only when the judgment is made that it "should not be happening".[7] Similarly, "foul words or blows in themselves are no outrage, but your judgement that they are so".[1] When anger arises, an individual should recognize that it is their own opinion that has irritated them, not the external action.[1]

The key to transforming oneself into a Stoic wise person (*sophos*) lies in the "correct use of impressions," which involves "not judging as good or bad anything that appears to one".[1] For Epictetus, only virtuous action is truly good, and only vicious action is truly bad.[1] Everything else is considered an "indifferent".[1] By exerting their

prohairesis, individuals can choose rationally how to react to impressions, thereby maintaining equanimity in the face of externals like criticism or praise.[18] Becoming troubled by criticism or elated by praise is considered a "moral evil" because it signifies a misjudgment of impressions and a ceding of control over one's life to others.[18]

This sequence of external event leading to involuntary impression, followed by the exercise of *prohairesis* and the voluntary act of assent, reveals a crucial "gap" where human freedom and moral responsibility reside. The individual's capacity to choose their internal response remains inviolable, even under extreme duress. This is a profound assertion of internal autonomy, regardless of external circumstances. Suffering arises when this critical gap is overlooked, and assent is given automatically or carelessly, allowing external events to dictate internal states.

While early Stoics extensively debated logic and epistemology, Epictetus concentrated almost exclusively on ethics.[1] However, his profound emphasis on the "correct use of impressions" and the "Discipline of Assent" [1] demonstrates that his ethical system is deeply dependent on a specific epistemological understanding. The ability to "not judge as good or bad anything that appears to one" [1] is an epistemological skill—it concerns how one interprets reality. His "innovations in epistemology" [4] were not for abstract knowledge but directly served the ethical goal of

eudaimonia. This reveals a practical, applied epistemology where the pursuit of truth about impressions is a direct means to ethical flourishing.

Epictetus's strong ethical stance is further underscored by his labeling of misjudging impressions as a "moral evil".[18] This implies that the failure to properly manage one's judgments is not merely a psychological error but a moral failing. It suggests that individuals bear a moral duty to cultivate rational judgment, as neglecting this duty leads to a state of moral compromise and "ceding control of one's life to others".[18] This perspective elevates the practice of discerning control and withholding assent from a self-help technique to a moral imperative.

3. The Path to Tranquility: Epictetus's Three Disciplines

To cultivate the "correct use of impressions" and achieve inner freedom, Epictetus prescribed a structured path of self-training, often organized into three interconnected disciplines. These disciplines provide a practical framework for applying the theoretical understanding of the dichotomy of control and the mechanism of impressions and assent.

Epictetus outlined three *topoi* (fields of study) or disciplines necessary for an individual striving for wisdom and goodness.[4] These are: the Discipline of Desire (or Aversion), focusing on what to aim for and what to avoid; the Discipline of Action, guiding behavior towards others; and the Discipline of Assent, managing judgments and impressions. These disciplines are deeply intertwined, much like the traditional Stoic topics of Logic, Ethics, and Physics.[12]

3.1. Discipline of Desire (Stoic Acceptance)

This discipline concerns desires and aversions, aiming to prevent individuals from failing to obtain what they desire and from falling into what they wish to avoid.[13] It necessitates exercising cardinal virtues such as Courage and Temperance, embodying Epictetus's famous slogan: "endure and renounce".[12] The core principle here is to desire only what is within one's control, as this ensures certainty of attainment and avoids disappointment stemming from things outside one's influence.[13] This re-engineers human motivation, transforming desire from a source of vulnerability (when directed externally) into a source of strength and tranquility (when directed internally).

A practical application of this discipline is encapsulated in the maxim: "Seek not for events to happen as you wish but wish events to happen as they do and your life will go smoothly and serenely".[7] This embodies the essence of

Amor Fati, the loving acceptance of fate, which liberates the individual from the frustration of resisting reality.[7]

Related exercises for cultivating this discipline include:

- **Negative Visualization (Premeditatio Malorum):** This involves envisioning the loss of valued possessions, relationships, or health to appreciate their present existence and prepare for their impermanence.[23] This practice is not morbid but serves as a proactive training for resilience, designed to "harden you up for life".[23] By repeatedly exposing oneself to imagined discomforts, an individual builds a psychological "immune system" against future, larger adversities, thereby becoming less susceptible to emotional disturbance from external events.
- **Voluntary Discomfort:** Deliberately placing oneself in uncomfortable situations (e.g., cold showers, fasting, sleeping on the floor) trains the individual to reduce attachment to comfort and build fortitude.[23] This practice helps one become less disturbed by external discomforts when they inevitably arise, reinforcing the idea that true well-being is not dependent on external ease.
- **Reminding oneself of impermanence:** This involves acknowledging that all things are "on loan" from Fortune and can be reclaimed without notice.[3] For instance, when a piece of china breaks, one should say, "I am fond of a piece of china," rather than "My china broke".[24] Similarly, when embracing a loved one, one might reflect, "I am kissing a mortal".[24] This practice is not about cultivating indifference, but about fostering a deeper appreciation for the preciousness of temporary things and preparing the mind for eventual loss, transforming potential

distress into acceptance.

3.2. Discipline of Action (Stoic Philanthropy)

This discipline governs how individuals interact with others and fulfill their duties within the community.[4] It emphasizes benevolence and wishing for the flourishing (*eudaimonia*) of all mankind.[12] The core principle is to act "for the common welfare" and "accord with value".[13] This involves extending natural affection (*oikeiosis*) to all humanity, recognizing shared rationality and interconnectedness.[12]

While direct control over others' happiness is impossible, actions should be guided by virtues such as justice.[12] Marcus Aurelius's contemplation on meeting difficult people exemplifies this: recognizing their shared rationality and avoiding anger, as working against others is contrary to nature.[13] This highlights that Stoic tranquility is not a selfish, isolated state; it is intrinsically linked to one's role in the human community. By acting virtuously towards others and for the common good, an individual lives "according to nature" [1], which is the path to *eudaimonia*. This demonstrates how external engagement, when properly motivated and executed, reinforces internal peace because it aligns with one's rational, social nature.

A related exercise for this discipline is the:

- **Reserve Clause (*Hupexairesis*):** When planning actions, individuals are advised to mentally rehearse potential obstacles and include the proviso "if that is what Zeus wills for me" or "fate permitting".[4] This is a sophisticated psychological tool that allows for committed action *without* attachment to the outcome. By mentally adding this clause, one pre-emptively accepts the potential failure of the external goal, thereby insulating their internal state from disappointment. For example, desiring a bath but also intending to keep one's will aligned with nature ensures that if the bath is spoiled, one remains undisturbed.[24] This transforms potential external hindrances into opportunities to demonstrate internal resilience, reinforcing the idea that the only true good is one's virtuous choice, not the external result.

3.3. Discipline of Assent (Stoic Mindfulness)

This discipline focuses on gaining control over one's assent to impressions, thereby avoiding deception and hasty judgment.[1] It falls under the Stoic topic of Logic, encompassing elements of psychology and epistemology.[12] The core principle is to "make proper use of impressions".[1] This means not being "carried away" by initial impressions, but pausing to examine them critically.[1]

A key practice within this discipline is *Prosochē* (Attention/Vigilance). This refers to the continuous presence of mind, acting as an "ever-vigilant watchman" over one's thoughts, judgments, and perceptions.[12] This is a form of Stoic mindfulness [12], not passive awareness but an active engagement with one's internal landscape. It is a demanding practice, requiring constant self-awareness and immediate intervention when an impression arises, effectively guarding the mental "fortress".[13]

Practical exercises for managing impressions include:

- **Pause and Examine Impressions (Cognitive Distancing):** Upon encountering a "harsh impression," one should immediately state: "You are merely an impression (*phantasia*) and not at all what you appear to be (*phainomenon*)".[17] This creates a crucial distance from the initial, often emotional, reaction. The next step is to "test and assess it with your criteria," primarily asking, "Is this something that is, or is not, in my control?" If it is not, the appropriate response is, "Then it's none of my concern".[24] This technique bears a striking resemblance to modern cognitive-behavioral therapy's (CBT) cognitive distancing techniques.[17]
- **Delaying Response/Withholding Assent:** Epictetus advises gaining "time and respite" before reacting to impressions, as this makes self-control easier.[1] This "delaying tactic" allows emotional disturbances to subside naturally, enabling a more objective evaluation.[17] The ultimate goal is to suspend judgment (*epochē*) in uncertain situations.[16]
- **"Other-ize":** When experiencing personal misfortune, an individual should recall how they react when similar events befall others, applying that same patient spirit to their own experiences.[24] This helps to depersonalize the event and view it more objectively, reducing its emotional impact.
- **Speaking without Judging:** This involves distinguishing between matters of fact and judgments. One should state only what is observed ("He bathes quickly") rather than adding a judgment ("He bathes badly") unless the reasons for the

action are known.[20] This promotes accurate perception and prevents assenting to false or unverified propositions, fostering clearer thought.

- **Recognizing the Source of Insult:** Epictetus famously stated, "It is not he who reviles or strikes you who insults you, but your opinion that these things are insulting".[18] When provoked, an individual should recognize that "your mind is complicit in the provocation".[24] This places responsibility for emotional reaction firmly within the individual's control.
- **Replacing Impressions:** Individuals are encouraged to introduce "fair and noble impression[s] to replace" base or disturbing ones.[1] This active mental substitution helps to reframe situations positively.

The striking similarities between Epictetus's methods (cognitive distancing, disputing irrational beliefs, delaying response) and modern Rational Emotive Behavior Therapy (REBT) and Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) are notable.[17] The "ABC model" (Activating event → Beliefs → Consequences) used in REBT [19] directly mirrors Epictetus's core premise. This suggests a deep, timeless understanding of human psychology. The fundamental mechanisms of emotional distress and their resolution have remained consistent across millennia, validating the enduring practical utility of Stoic philosophy.

Table 2: Epictetus's Three Disciplines for Inner Freedom

Discipline	Primary Focus	Core Principle	Key Practices/Exercises	Desired Outcome
Desire	Managing desires and aversions	Desire only what is in your control; accept what is not	Negative Visualization, Voluntary Discomfort, Reminding of Impermanence, *Amor Fati*	Freedom from disappointment, serenity, acceptance of fate
Action	Guiding behavior towards others	Act virtuously for the common good, with detachment from external outcomes	Reserve Clause (*Hupexairesis*), Social Responsibility (*Oikeiosis*)	Ethical conduct, benevolence, alignment with universal nature
Assent	Managing	Withhold assent	*Prosochē*	Freedom from

	judgments and impressions	from false or unexamined impressions; use reason to evaluate	(Vigilance/Mindfulness), Cognitive Distancing ("You are merely an impression"), Delaying Response, "Other-izing," Speaking without Judging, Recognizing Source of Insult	deception, clear judgment, imperturbability

4. The Outcome: Inner Freedom and Serenity

The diligent and consistent application of Epictetus's principles and disciplines culminates in a profound state of inner freedom and tranquility, which are central to the Stoic concept of flourishing.

The ultimate goal of Stoic philosophy, as taught by Epictetus, is *eudaimonia* ('happiness' or 'flourishing'), achieved by living a life of reason and virtue, "according to nature".[1] This

eudaimonia is characterized by *ataraxia* (imperturbability or freedom from disturbance), *apatheia* (freedom from passion or unhealthy emotions), and *eupatheiai* ('good feelings' or rational emotions).[1] Tranquility is achieved when an individual masters their desires and emotions, aligning their choices fully with nature.[11] When one guards what is inherently theirs (their choices, judgments) and desires only those things, they become unhindered and secure, as these internal goods cannot be taken away.[11] True happiness is secured by abandoning the frustrating pursuit or avoidance of uncontrollable things.[3] The "wise person" (

sophos) is immune to misfortune because their power of rationality allows them to correctly use impressions and not judge externals as inherently good or bad.[1]

Epictetus consistently reiterates that authentic freedom and peace are found in mastering one's internal responses. "Authentic freedom comes from understanding the difference between what depends on our efforts and what does not. This way we

can focus our energy on what we can really achieve".[9] He illustrates this with powerful examples: "Sickness is a hindrance to the body, but not to your ability to choose, unless that is your choice. Lameness is a hindrance to the leg, but not to your ability to choose".[6] This demonstrates that external obstacles are hindrances to something else, but never to one's true self or

prohairesis. By cultivating a mindset that focuses on intrinsic values and personal integrity, individuals can shift their focus away from societal pressures and cultivate a more fulfilling and mentally healthy life.[8] Ultimately, "Freedom and happiness are won by disregarding things that lie beyond our control".[20]

The consistent message across Epictetus's teachings is that focusing on internal elements leads to freedom, happiness, and serenity.[8] This implies a radical transformation of an individual's experience of life. By shifting the locus of control and value inward, the individual becomes impervious to external vicissitudes. This is not merely coping; it is a fundamental re-wiring of one's relationship with reality, where external events lose their power to disturb, and internal virtue becomes the sole determinant of well-being. This represents a profound shift from a reactive to a proactive and self-sufficient mode of existence.

The concept of the *sophos* (wise person) [1] represents the ideal outcome of this philosophical journey. The

sophos is described as someone whose "power of rationality is a fragment of God" and who lives "according to nature," accepting fate as coming directly from "divine intelligence".[1] This elevates the pursuit of tranquility from a purely psychological endeavor to a spiritual or cosmic alignment. The ideal Stoic is not just emotionally stable but lives in harmony with the rational order of the universe, embodying a form of practical divinity. This adds a profound layer of meaning and purpose to the internal struggle for self-mastery.

Conclusion

Epictetus's central teaching—that "It is not things themselves that disturb people but their judgements about those things"—is a cornerstone of Stoic philosophy, offering a timeless framework for understanding and managing human emotional experience.[7] He meticulously delineated this principle by emphasizing the crucial distinction

between what is within our control (our internal judgments, desires, and actions) and what is not (external events and circumstances).[3]

Emotional disturbance arises when individuals misjudge impressions (*phantasiai*) by assigning inherent good or bad qualities to externals, rather than recognizing their neutrality. The unique human faculty of *prohairesis* (moral purpose/volition) empowers individuals to choose to give or withhold assent (*synkatathesis*) to these impressions, thereby controlling their internal response.[1] To cultivate this control, Epictetus prescribed three interconnected disciplines—Desire, Action, and Assent—each offering practical exercises like cognitive distancing, negative visualization, and the reserve clause, designed to train the mind for resilience and rational judgment.[12]

The rigorous application of these principles leads to *ataraxia* (imperturbability) and *eudaimonia* (flourishing), a state of inner freedom and serenity derived from mastering one's internal responses and aligning with nature.[1] The enduring relevance of Epictetus's teachings is underscored by their striking parallels with modern cognitive-behavioral therapies (CBT and REBT), which share the fundamental premise that our beliefs and interpretations are the primary drivers of emotional distress.[17] This demonstrates the profound and practical wisdom of Epictetus, whose insights continue to offer a powerful guide for navigating the complexities of human experience and achieving a tranquil, flourishing life.

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